Gibbs, so that in this particular field no recognition was to be mine.

While an instructor in Munich, I waited for years in vain for an appointment to a professorship. Of course, my prospects for getting one were slight, for theoretical physics had not as yet come to be recognized as a special discipline. All the more compellingly grew in me the desire to win, somehow, a reputation in the field of science.

Guided by this desire, I decided to submit a paper for the prize to be awarded in 1887 by the Philosophical Faculty of Göttingen. The subject to be discussed was, “The Nature of Energy.” After I had completed my paper, in the spring of 1885, I was offered the associate professorship in theoretical physics at the University of Kiel. This offer came as a message of deliverance. The moment when I paid my respects to Ministerial Director Althoff in his suite in the Hotel Marienbad, and he informed me of the particulars and conditions of my appointment, was, and will always be, one of the happiest of my life. For even though my life in my parents’ house was as beautiful and contented as any man could wish for, my longing for independence kept growing within me, and I was yearning for a home of my own.

To be sure, I suspected, and by no means without reason, that this smile of good fortune was actually not so much a reward for my scientific accomplishments as a practical result of the circumstance that Gustav Karsten, Professor of Physics in Kiel, happened to be a close friend of my father. Nevertheless, this realization could not mar my supreme happiness, and I was firmly resolved to justify the confidence in me in every way in my power.

I soon moved to Kiel, where I put the finishing touches on my paper, and submitted it in Göttingen. It won second prize. Besides my entry, two other papers had been submitted on the subject, but these two were awarded no prize at all. Obviously, I was wondering why my paper had failed to win first prize, and I found the answer in the text of the detailed decision of the Faculty of Göttingen. The judges set forth a few points of criticism of minor import, and then stated: “Finally, the Faculty must withhold its approval from the remarks in which the author tries to appraise Weber’s Law.” Now, the story behind these remarks was: W. Weber was the Professor of Physics in Göttingen, between whom and Helmholtz there existed at the time a vigorous scientific controversy, in which I had expressly sided with the latter. I think that I make no mistake in considering this circumstance to have been the main reason for the decision of the Faculty of Göttingen to withhold the first prize from me. But while with my attitude I had incurred the displeasure of the scholars of Göttingen, it gained me the benevolent attention of those of Berlin, the results of which I was soon to feel.

No sooner had I finished my paper for Göttingen than I returned to my